



DECLARING WAR: Rajapakse (left) has decided on an all-out offensive against LTTE's Prabhakaran (above) and Tamil guerrillas

BACK TO THE GUN...AGAIN

Ending the peace process, the Government embarks on a perilous military offensive against LTTE

■ **By Christine Jayasinghe in Colombo**

As New Year resolutions go it must be the grimmest ever being made. The Sri Lankan military chief Lt. Gen. Sarath Fonseka vowed to kill 3,000 Tamil Tigers in the first six months of the year and promised to wipe out Tamil separatism. Then President Mahinda Rajapakse announced that he was formally ending the five-year-old tottering ceasefire agreement with the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE). The signal was clear: the Government had decided to launch a major military offensive that the rest of the world, including India, saw as tantamounting to shutting the door on the peace process.

Soon enough plenty of blood was being spilled, not just in the jungles of the north, but in the streets of

Colombo and its environs. The year began with a gunman shooting dead T. Maheshwaram, a Tamil legislator, while he prayed at a Hindu temple in capital Colombo on New Year's Day. Then a roadside bomb attack the day after killed five persons near military installations in the capital. Five days later, Sri Lanka's Minister for Nation Building D.M. Dassanayake was assassinated in another roadside bombing that was quickly followed by a parcel bomb attack in the heart of Colombo.

The string of attacks came amid claims by the military that it had won an upper hand in the battle against LTTE, after having dismantled their civil administrative structures in the east of the island in July last year. Air strikes against key rebel installations and the deaths of the LTTE's political wing

leader S. P. Thamilselvam and top intelligence official S. Ravishanker (alias Colonel Charles) among others, which the military has claimed responsibility for, have boosted the drive to retake the northern rebel-held districts of Mannar, Kilinochchi and Mullaitivu. There were even unconfirmed reports that LTTE supremo Velupillai Prabhakaran was injured in an aerial attack. Coming on the heels of reclamation of the eastern province last year, the Government has convinced people that the end of LTTE is only few months away.

So the Government's January 2 exit from the bipartisan ceasefire agreement—signed in 2002 and sponsored by peace broker Norway—received widespread support among the Sinhala majority. It comes against a background of steadily worsening